inside Russia. Erwin Rommel, a decorated general nicknamed ‘Desert Fox’, had trounced the Allies in the African war theatre. In June 1942, Rommel took tens of thousands of troops prisoner in Tobruk. Also in June 1942, Hitler ordered a massacre in Czechoslovakia’s Lidice village, which was reduced to ashes on his orders. On 4 July 1942, German bombers attacked an Arctic convoy of the Allies, code-named PQ17, sending it into such disarray that for weeks together 100,000 tonnes of cargo, including 210 planes and 3,350 vehicles, went missing. Within the Congress itself, there were heated debates on the path ahead, and socialist factions found it necessary to form breakaway organizations. The scene was very different a decade ago.

In 1931, the frail saint of Sabarmati Ashram had taken out a march from Ahmedabad to Dandi in an act of quiet defiance that made the world take notice of the Congress as a force to reckon with. For several years after, the Congress went from strength to strength, attracting the youth from across India to its idea of demanding swaraj (self-rule) through a non-violent struggle. These were precisely the years when fascism was on an ascendancy in Europe. Hitler had come to power in 1933. For the youth in India, Germany’s enmity with Britain could have turned them towards fascism. But that didn’t happen, thanks to Gandhi’s inspirational leadership. Nobody in India at the time, barring the RSS, was drawn to Hitler’s fascism as a possible option.[2] Not even when differences arose, say between Dr Ambedkar and Gandhi. Not even for Subhas Chandra Bose, who had very different ideas from Gandhi about ways of securing Independence, but there was no racial prejudice in his world view—Muslims, Hindus and Christians stood shoulder to shoulder in his Azad Hind Fauj, as indeed did men and women. Their differences notwithstanding, there was an unspoken consensus among India’s great leaders that a better future for the Indian people could only lie on the path of democracy.

In 1921, nearly a decade before the Dandi March, the Congress was just emerging from a bitter factional fight between its moderates and extremists. A generation of leaders such as Bal Gangadhar Tilak, Lala Lajpat Rai and Bipin Chandra Pal had faded out. In 1920, Gandhi had been on a whirlwind